Safe Digging Essentials

A practical LSBUD Insight guide to help users understand the basics, choose the right next step and reduce risk before ground is disturbed.

Core message

Start with the risk, not the form.

If work may disturb the ground, ask what could be below before work begins.

1	2	3	4	5
Plan	**Locate**	**Verify**	**Excavate**	**Review**

For: householders, contractors, surveyors, designers, pack collators, estate teams and managers.

Use this guide to: plan the work, identify likely underground-service risk, understand when a OneCall Utility Search may be needed and know when to escalate to Top-Up, survey, Open Water, Environmental or Large Site routes.

Version 2.0 | Improved layout and field-guide style | Prepared for the LSBUD Insight Library

1. Start with the risk, not the form

Safe digging is not just about submitting a search.

A search is one part of a safe system of work. The user still needs to understand the site, review results, follow asset owner instructions and use safe excavation methods.

Ask first

What could be below?

What information is missing?

What extra checks are needed before work starts?

If the work will disturb the ground, do not rely on assumptions. Use the right search, guidance or specialist service before work begins.

HSE’s HSG47 guidance identifies three basic elements of a safe system of work during excavation: planning the work, locating and identifying buried services, and safe excavation.

Plain-English safe digging principle

If the work creates a hole, trench, post hole, excavation, duct route, anchor point or ground penetration, ask what could be below before work begins.

2. Safe digging workflow

1	2	3	4	5
Plan	Locate	Verify	Excavate	Review

Stage	What it means	Output
Plan	Understand the activity, location, depth, method and consequence of error.	Clear brief and work boundary.
Locate	Use OneCall, site records, visible clues and competent locating methods.	Known information and remaining gaps.
Verify	Check uncertainty. Expose carefully. Escalate if records and site clues conflict.	Confirmed or escalated risk.
Excavate	Use safe digging methods, suitable tools, supervision and emergency readiness.	Controlled work activity.
Review	Record what was found. Update evidence. Repeat searches when needed.	Reusable learning and audit trail.

Avoid shortcut thinking

Plans help you plan.

Plans do not prove exact position, depth or live status.

3. Do you need a utility search?

Ask these questions before work starts. If the answer is yes or not sure, a OneCall Utility Search should be considered.

- Will the ground be broken, drilled, driven, excavated, trenched or penetrated?
- Could buried services be nearby?
- Are covers, chambers, stopcocks, meters, cabinets or service entries visible nearby?
- Could the work affect a road, verge, driveway, boundary, garden, building intake or footway?
- Would a strike cause injury, outage, delay, environmental harm or major cost?
- Are plans, site records or local knowledge incomplete or unclear?

Signal	What it may mean	Recommended next step
Ground disturbance	Underground services may be present.	Consider OneCall Utility Search.
Boundary or intake nearby	Service connections may be present.	Review plans and trace likely routes.
Unclear plans	Asset uncertainty remains.	Consider Top-Up or survey.
Large or complex site	Standard enquiry may not be enough.	Consider Large Site or Comprehensive route.
Water or environmental features	Additional constraints may apply.	Consider Open Water or Environmental report.

4. What plans can and cannot do

Utility plans and asset records are important, but they are not the whole safe digging process.

Utility plans can help you	Utility plans do not automatically
• Identify known asset owners. • Plan the work area. • Decide where extra checks are needed. • Brief site teams. • Support evidence packs.	• Prove exact position. • Prove exact depth. • Show every private service. • Replace site checks. • Confirm a service is dead.

Key message

The question is not only: do I have plans?

The better question is: are the plans good enough for this work and this risk?

If the consequence of being wrong is high, escalate. Use Top-Up, survey, competent review or a more comprehensive route.

5. Choose your next route

Use this page as a routing guide. The right answer depends on the user, the activity, the location and the consequence of error.

Situation	Recommended route
I only need simple advice.	Use the Library: FAQs, Wiki, checklists and safe digging guides.
I am planning ground disturbance.	Start OneCall Utility Search for the defined area.
Records may be incomplete.	Consider Top-Up Search.
The job is high-value, complex or high consequence.	Consider Comprehensive Premium or managed review.
I need physical location or verification.	Request Select Surveys / PAS128 / GPR quote.
The site is large, linear or complex.	Use Large Site route.
Water or environmental constraints may be relevant.	Consider Open Water or Environmental Constraints report.
I manage repeat work or teams.	Consider Pro account with history, training and service bundles.

6. Common user scenarios

The same safe digging question can lead to different recommendations depending on who is asking.

User type	Likely need	Recommended first step
Householder	Plain-English guidance.	Checklist plus OneCall if digging is planned.
Fencing contractor	Avoid shallow service connections.	Fencing guide, Service Connection Risk Guide and OneCall.
C2 pack collator	Evidence and repeat searches.	OneCall, Top-Up and 28-day reminders.
Architect / designer	Early design risk visibility.	Utility Plans Explained and survey quote route.
Environmental consultant	Site constraints and water risk.	Open Water or Environmental Constraints report.
Senior manager	Governance and repeat service use.	Pro account, training and service dashboard.

7. Pre-dig checklist

Use this checklist before work starts. Keep the list visible in the method statement, briefing pack or site file.

- Submit a OneCall / LSBUD enquiry where ground disturbance is planned.
- Review returned asset plans and asset owner instructions.
- Check visible clues on site: stopcocks, covers, meters, cabinets, chambers, ducts and service entries.
- Trace likely routes from visible features to building intake points.
- Mark suspected routes using spray paint, flags or agreed site markings.
- Assume services are live unless proven otherwise.
- Use safe digging techniques near known or suspected services.
- Keep emergency contacts and actions ready before work begins.
- Pause and reassess if site evidence conflicts with records.

Stop-work trigger

If a service is found where it was not expected, pause.
Review the plan before work continues.

8. Emergency readiness

Before work starts, know what to do if something goes wrong.

Keep ready	Why it matters
Asset owner emergency numbers	The right contact saves time if a service is damaged.
Site manager and client contacts	Immediate escalation supports control and reporting.
Emergency services route if required	Some incidents need urgent public safety response.
Stop-work instruction	People must know when and how to stop work.
Incident record process	Photos, notes and times help if it is safe to record them.

If a service is damaged:

- Stop work.
- Keep people away.
- Do not touch exposed or damaged services.
- Do not try to repair the service.
- Call the relevant emergency contact.
- Record the incident when safe to do so.

Sources and limitations

This guide is original LSBUD Insight library content. It is designed as a public-facing guide and does not reproduce HSG47 or third-party guidance in full.

Source	How it informed this guide
Health and Safety Executive, HSG47: Avoiding danger from underground services, Third edition, 2014.	Used as the key source for the safe-system framing: planning the work, locating and identifying buried services, and safe excavation.
Health and Safety Executive excavation and underground services guidance.	Supports the emphasis on planning, obtaining suitable information and taking precautions before disturbing the ground.
LSBUD Insight Persona Engine and Library Catalogue.	Used to align this guide with library-first recommendations and service routes such as OneCall, Top-Up, Select Surveys, Open Water, Environmental, Large Site and Pro account.

Limitations: This document is general guidance only. Users must consider legal duties, client requirements, CDM duties where relevant, current HSE guidance, asset owner instructions, site-specific hazards, competent advice and local procedures.

Recommended action: if works may disturb the ground, use LSBUD Insight to access relevant Library content and consider OneCall Utility Search or another route suited to the activity and site.